

Economic History II

Elite recruitment and bureaucratic reform

FGV EPGE

Outline of the class

- Two papers on **elite recruitment** inside a regime with no electoral channel for discontent.
- **Bai and Jia (2016)**: China abolishes its civil service exam in 1905, and the dynasty falls six years later.
- **Chiovelli, Fergusson, Martínez, Torres and Valencia Caicedo**: Spain professionalizes its colonial administration in the 1780s, and loses the empire.
- Opposite reforms. In both, the group most affected was the one with the means to organize against the regime.

The abolition of China's civil service exam

Bai and Jia (2016), *Econometrica*

The question

- **Elite recruitment**: who is allowed into the ruling class, and by which route.
- Old claim (Pareto, Mosca): regimes are stable when a legitimate path into the elite stays open.
- Hard to test. Recruitment systems normally change slowly, alongside everything else.
- China in 1905: the route was closed in a single edict.

ELITE RECRUITMENT AND POLITICAL STABILITY: THE IMPACT OF THE ABOLITION OF CHINA'S CIVIL SERVICE EXAM

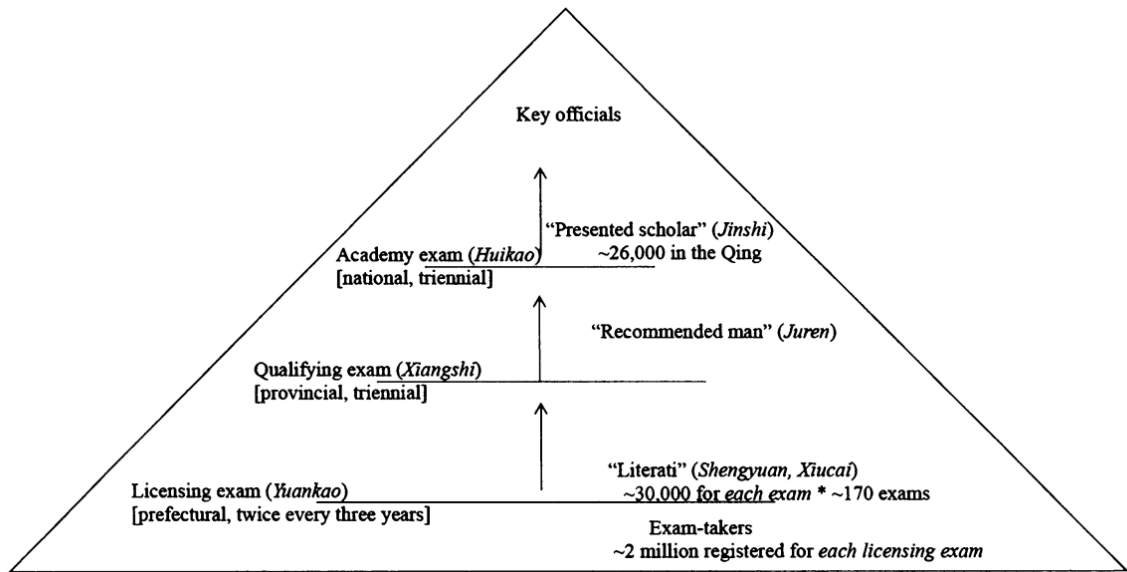
BY YING BAI AND RUIXUE JIA¹

This paper studies how the abolition of an elite recruitment system—China's civil exam system that lasted over 1,300 years—affects political stability. Employing a panel data set across 262 prefectures and exploring the variations in the quotas on the entry-level exam candidates, we find that higher quotas per capita were associated with a higher probability of revolution participation after the abolition and a higher incidence of uprisings in 1911 that marked the end of the 2,000 years of imperial rule. This finding is robust to various checks including using the number of small rivers and short-run exam performance before the quota system as instruments. The patterns in the data appear most consistent with the interpretation that in regions with higher quotas per capita under the exam system, more would-be elites were negatively affected by the abolition. In addition, we document that modern human capital in the form of those studying in Japan also contributed to the revolution and that social capital strengthened the effect of quotas on revolution participation.

KEYWORDS: Elite recruitment, mobilization, revolution, social mobility, civil service exam.

The civil service exam (keju)

- Established in 605 AD under the Sui, expanded under the Song, and the main channel of elite recruitment under the Ming (1368-1644) and the Qing (1644-1911).
- Content dominated by the Confucian texts.
- Passing bought entry to the **gentry**, a group much larger than the officials.
- For more than 1,300 years, the central institution linking the elite to the state.
- Gentry plus immediate family: around 2% of the population in the mid-19th century.



Three stages

- **Entry**: the prefectural licensing exam (*yuankao*), twice every three years. Those who passed were the literati (*xiuca*).
- **Provincial**: the triennial qualifying exam (*xiangshi*). Those who passed, the recommended men (*juren*), became officials.
- **National**: the academy exam in the capital. Around 26,000 presented scholars (*jinshi*) across the Qing's 112 national exams, and over 90% of the 4,200 key officials held that degree.
- The entry exam is the paper's margin: it is what a commoner could realistically aim at.

What the degree bought, and what it cost

- The literati were exempt from taxes and from corporal punishment, and could manage local affairs, work as secretaries to officials, or teach.
- No limit on age or on the number of attempts, and the degree could not be inherited.
- Around **2 million** men registered for each licensing exam, about 2.5% of males aged 15 to 49.
- Studying meant forgoing work: an estimated 1.5 acres of land to support one candidate, a threshold 30 to 40% of households cleared. Clans financed promising individuals from poor families.

How the exam was kept fair

- Papers were transcribed before marking, so examiners could not recognize the calligraphy.
- The Emperor personally supervised the final stage.
- Children of officials sat the exam in their parents' region of origin.
- Corruption survived: in 1781, **56 officials** were executed in Gansu for selling degrees.

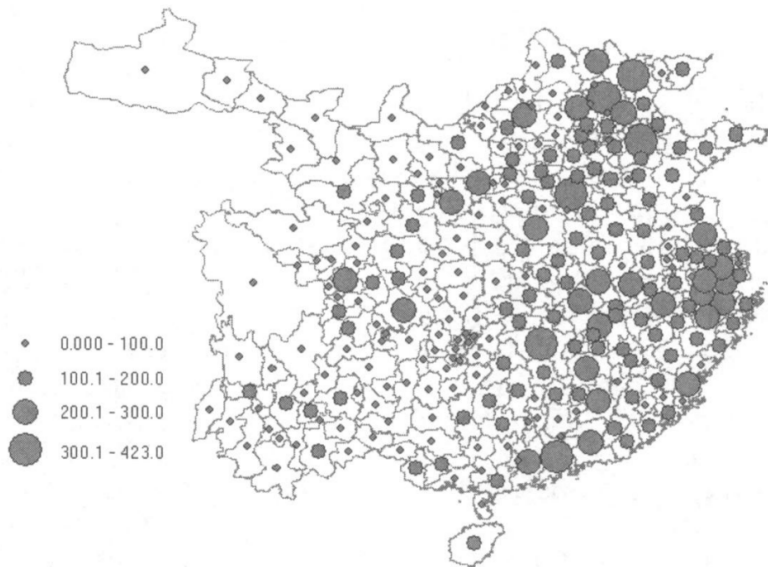
Quotas

- Passes were capped by a **quota**, set at the prefecture level for the entry exam.
- The rule: one quota for each county, plus an extra quota shared across the prefecture.
- 262 prefectures. Mean quota 114 places; per million inhabitants, mean 136.
- Empire-wide, around 30,000 places per exam against 2 million registrations. Source: the *Imperially Established Institutes and Laws of the Great Qing Dynasty* (Kun et al., 1899).

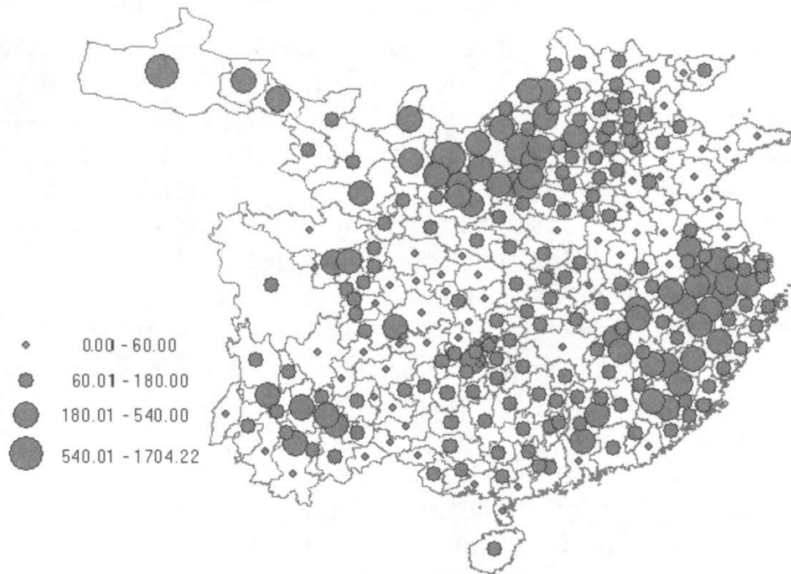
Why the quotas are usable

- Assigned in 1724, revised once in 1873 after the Taiping Rebellion, then frozen until abolition.
- Lumpy: the common values are 8, 12, 15 and 20, over 70% of the observations.
- The paper's term is **state simplification**: the state could not run a proportional rule, so it rounded.
- Consequence: quotas per person do not track a prefecture's wealth, its population growth or its taste for conflict.

(a) Spatial Distribution of Quotas



(b) Spatial Distribution of Quotas per Million People



Reading the two maps

- First map: quotas in levels. Large, rich prefectures get large quotas, as expected.
- Second map: quotas **per million people**. The ranking scrambles.
- Thinly populated prefectures in the west can offer the best odds per head.
- Province differences explain only 30% of the variation, so most of the contrast is between neighbors inside a province.

The abolition

- Defeats by the West made the exam's content look like a cause of underdevelopment: reciting the classics rather than engineering or science.
- January 1904: gradual abolition approved, to be spread over the next decade.
- **2 September 1905**: Empress Dowager Cixi endorsed a memorandum abolishing the exam at all levels, at once.
- The trigger was Japan's defeat of Russia in 1904-1905, credited to the Meiji Restoration.

The memorandum, and why the break was abrupt

- Its claim: “the secret of Prussia’s victory over France and of Japan’s over Russia” lay in their primary schools.
- The dynasty meant to build a Western-style school system instead. The same memorandum admitted the money and the teachers were not there.
- Elsewhere the shift from hereditary to meritocratic recruitment took generations: in Europe alongside the Industrial and French Revolutions, in the United States over about a century.
- China 1905 is a single dated break, which is what makes the effect separable.

Measuring instability

- **1,304 registered revolutionaries**, 1900 to 1906, coded to their prefecture of origin.
- Source: member rosters of the six major revolutionary groups, the largest being the Chinese Revolutionary Alliance.
- Second measure: the spatial pattern of the early uprisings of 1911, coded from a Tokyo newspaper map.
- The two line up across prefectures, correlation 0.32.

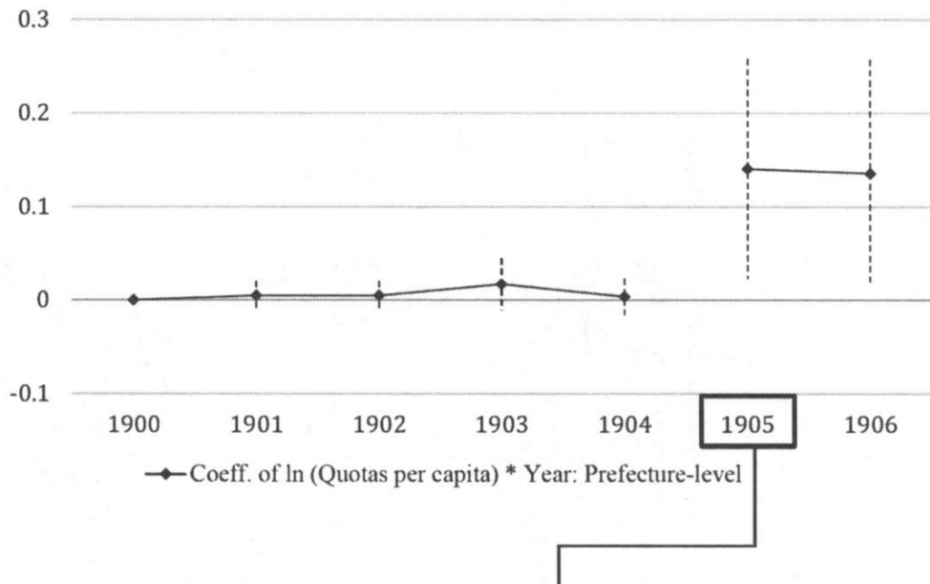
Who the revolutionaries were

- Median age 24. The literati degree was typically obtained around the same age.
- Of the 86 killed in the Yellow Flower Mound revolt of April 1911, backgrounds are known for 32.
- 30 of those 32 had received a traditional education; only 7 had a grandfather or uncle who was an official.
- Families that could pay for some education, but not the upper gentry.

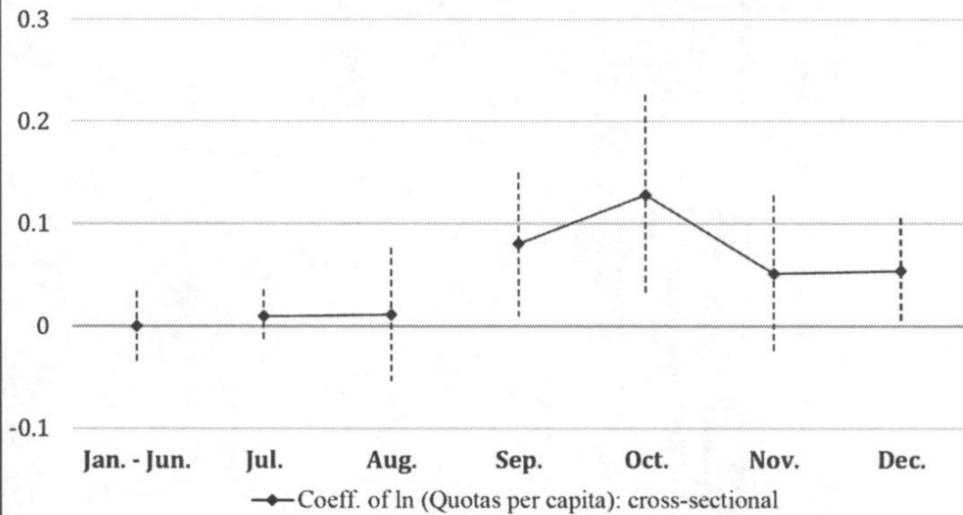
The comparison

- High-quota against low-quota prefectures, before and after September 1905.
- Quotas were assigned a century and a half earlier, so they are not a response to anything happening in 1905.
- Province-specific trends are absorbed, so the contrast is between neighbors under the same provincial government.
- Controls for population, area, coast, major rivers, treaty ports and city size.

(a) Prefecture-level Analysis (1900-1906)



(b) Cross-sectional Correlations in the Monthly Data



The result, and its timing

- One standard deviation more quota per person, a wide but not extreme gap between prefectures: about **6 percentage points** more likely to produce a revolutionary after 1905.
- Average participation over the period is 16 percentage points, so the effect is around 40% of it. For the early uprisings of 1911: about 4 percentage points, roughly 25% of the mean incidence.
- First panel, year by year with 1900 as reference: flat through 1904, the jump lands in 1905 and holds in 1906.
- Second panel, month by month inside 1905: nothing in July or August, the link appears from **September**.

Things that could go wrong, and the Boxer check

- High-quota prefectures might simply be more rebellious places, or the 1905 surge might be a general upheaval with nothing to do with the exam.
- The Boxer Rebellion (1899-1901) ran on proto-nationalist sentiment and hostility to foreigners, and most of its rebels were landless peasants.
- Quotas do not predict Boxer incidence at all, in the whole sample or in the north where it concentrated.
- Quotas also fail to predict party identification after the revolution succeeded.

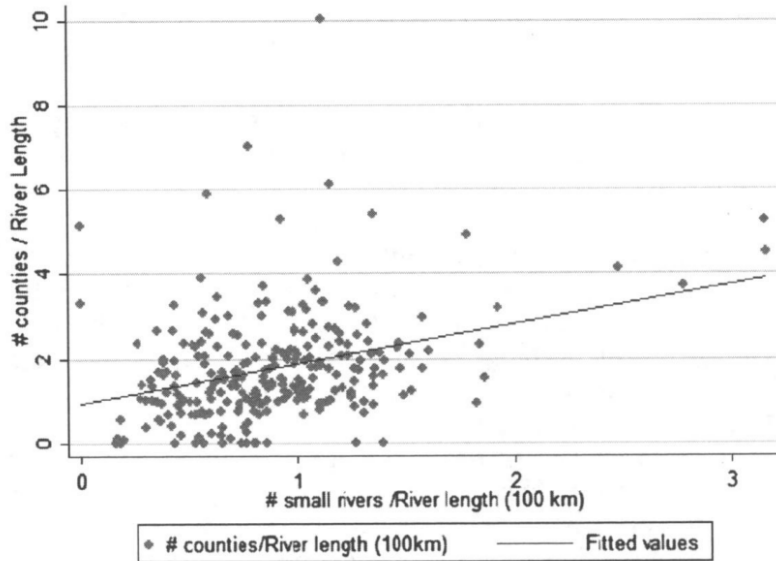
Other shocks in the same decade

- Defeat in the Sino-Japanese War of 1895, the Hundred Days' Reform of 1898, the Boxer Protocol of 1901.
- All raised the tax burden or humiliated the dynasty. None changed elite recruitment.
- Quotas show no comparable effect in 1895, 1898 or 1901.
- Newspaper density, foreign enclaves and Japanese enclaves do not account for the 1905 break either.

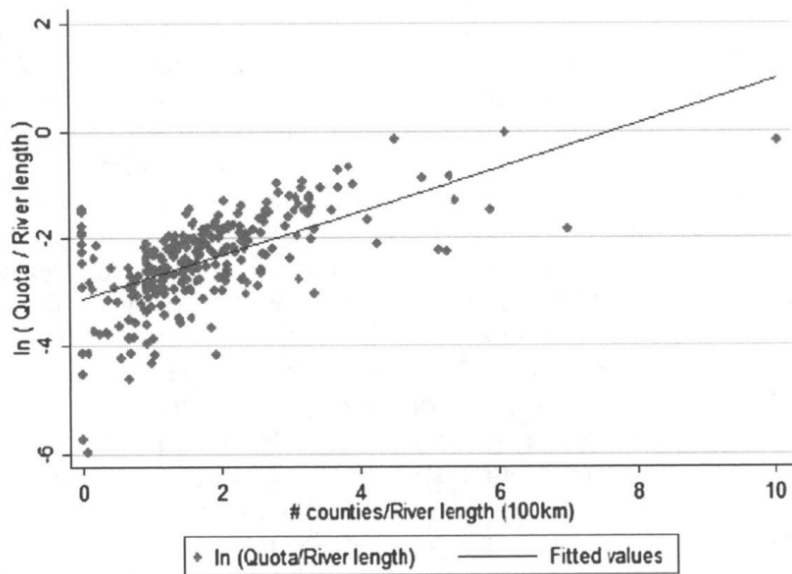
Geography behind the quotas

- Counties formed around rivers, but many rivers inside one county raised administrative costs.
- So more **small rivers**, given total river length, means more counties, and each county carried a quota.
- A fixed feature of the landscape moved quotas per person, with no obvious route to 1911.
- Checked against transport importance, crop suitability, drought and flood history, and basin fragmentation.

(a) #Small Rivers/Riv.Length and #Counties



(b) #Counties and the Quota



The chain in the data

- First panel: more small rivers per unit of river length, more counties.
- Second panel: more counties, higher quota.
- A second, historical source of variation: short-run swings in exam performance before 1425, when the quota system was first introduced.
- Both routes give the same sign, and about twice the effect of the simple before-and-after comparison.

Why would abolition produce revolutionaries?

Four candidate explanations

- **State capacity**: abolition signaled a state that was already falling apart.
- **Elite eligibility**: commoners who hoped to become elites lost the route.
- **Elite resistance**: those who had already passed lost standing.
- **Modern human capital**: new schools and study abroad carried modernizing ideology.
- Any of them must be correlated with quotas per person *and* change discontinuously in September 1905.

Elite eligibility: the route closes

- Before 1905, quotas per person strongly predicted where the empire's political newcomers came from.
- In 1904 the link is tight. In 1907, with newcomers now selected on foreign schooling, it is halved and gone.
- The would-be elite in a high-quota prefecture lost the prospect of moving up.
- Background from the historical literature: 40 to 60% of successful candidates came from families with no officials in them.

Prospects or free time

- Two channels. The lost prospect of rising, or a lower cost of rebelling once studying stopped.
- Test: where the exam had paid off more before 1905 (more key officials produced), the quota effect after 1905 is larger.
- That amplification is what the **prospects** channel predicts. The free-time channel predicts none.
- The paper's model adds a second prediction, on social capital, tested below.

Elite resistance fails

- Measures of the prospects of *existing* elites do nothing: presented scholars per quota, officials per presented scholar.
- The number of key officials in office in 1905 dampens the effect, if anything.
- Consistent with sitting top elites not losing, and perhaps gaining from less competition from commoners.
- Gentry provision of local public goods, proxied by weather volatility, explains nothing either.

The other two hypotheses

- Students who had gone to Japan predict revolutionary participation strongly on their own, which is direct evidence for Huntington's modernization argument.
- But including them barely moves the quota effect. Two channels into the revolution, not one.
- If the state were simply collapsing, provincial taxes should move with quotas after 1905. Land taxes (1893, 1903, 1908) and non-agricultural taxes (1891-1908) show no such break.
- State capacity was eroding across the late Qing, but not discontinuously in September 1905.

Social capital

- Participation is a coordination problem: the payoff to joining rises with how many others join.
- Social capital is proxied by linguistic fragmentation and polarization across prefectures.
- Where groups are more fragmented, the quota effect is smaller; polarization cuts it by about a third.
- Losing prospects supplies the motive; local ties turn the motive into organization.

What people said at the time

- Shanghai newspapers debated within days whether a completely different school system could actually be built.
- Zhu Zhisan, a Hubei gentry member, recorded in his diary in September 1905 that many exam hopefuls had cried.
- Liu Dapeng, in an isolated Shanxi village, heard that students were joining new organizations, and worried that “disasters and calamities will arise from them”.
- Franke: abolition produced “the dissolution of existing political and social order”.

The end of the dynasty

- 10 October 1911: the Wuchang Uprising in Hubei.
- Provinces declared independence within weeks.
- 12 February 1912: the abdication of the last emperor, Puyi.
- Over **2,000 years** of imperial rule ended, and China's republican era began.

Takeaway

- Nobody claims the revolution was fought to restore the exam.
- Abolition destroyed a career path, and the men on that path joined organizations that already existed.
- Huntington's caution, quoted by the authors: revolutions “necessarily involve[d] the alienation of many groups from the existing order”.
- Closer to home: the Brazilian *concurso* is also a capped, rule-bound route into a protected career, with very unequal odds per candidate across careers and regions.

The Bourbon reforms

Chiovelli, Fergusson, Martínez, Torres and Valencia Caicedo

Bourbon Reforms, State Capacity, and Revolution in the Spanish Empire*

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Abstract

We study state modernization, extractive institutions, and political upheaval in the colonial world. We explore the intendency system: a new corps of governors overseeing a new set of administrative units introduced throughout Spain's American empire in the 1780s. We show that the reform led to improvements in state capacity along three dimensions: (i) state presence in peripheral areas; (ii) fiscal revenue; (iii) production of cartographic information. The reform also led to fewer Indigenous rebellions but increased anti-Spanish sentiment among local elites – who saw their economic privileges curtailed – and bolstered Latin America's independence movement in the early 19th century.

The second paper

- A reform that **built** the state rather than closing a career ladder.
- Spain's **intendancy system**, introduced across the American empire from 1782.
- Three dimensions of state capacity improve: territorial presence, revenue, cartographic knowledge.
- Indigenous rebellions fall. Creole hostility to the Crown rises.

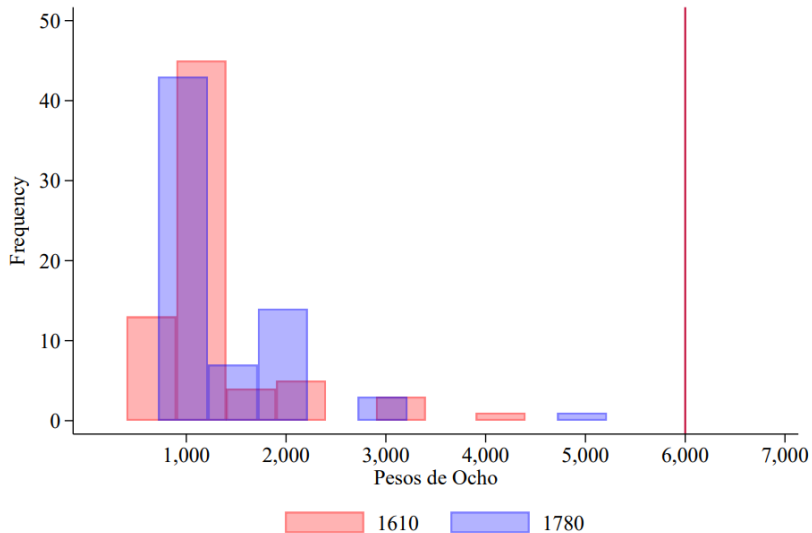
The empire and its money

- Four viceroyalties (New Spain, New Granada, Peru, Rio de la Plata) and twelve high courts (*Audiencias*) in the major cities. Outside them, *corregimientos* under a **corregidor**.
- Royal treasuries (*cajas reales*) collected revenue, paid expenses and shipped the surplus to Spain.
- Four main sources: the **Indigenous poll tax**, mining taxes on gold and silver, Crown monopolies such as tobacco, and taxes on domestic and external trade.
- Plus *donativos*: extraordinary war contributions, formally voluntary gifts of loyalty, mostly from local elites.

The corregidor

- Introduced in the 16th century to centralize authority and improve governance.
- The Crown sold the post: a large payment up front for a five-year term, then a term spent recouping it.
- The **repartimiento**: forced sale of overpriced goods, cattle and textiles, to Indigenous communities.
- The poll tax was skimmed too: base under-reported, exempt people charged, part of the revenue embezzled.

Figure C1: Distribution of Corregidores' Wages



The corregidor in the record

- Corregidor salaries in 1610 and in 1780 sit almost on top of each other. Average pay in 1780 was 1,380 pesos; the vertical line at **6,000 pesos** is what an intendant would earn after the reform.
- A widely circulated exposé of 1749: “the tyranny suffered by the Indians stems from the insatiable desire for riches on the part of those who come from Spain to rule over them”.
- Lynch: “the very archetype of erring officialdom, whose repertoire included almost every device known in the history of administrative corruption”.
- Golte: in Peru in 1754 the repartimiento mobilized almost half of the Indigenous workforce, against 6% drafted for the mines through the *mita*.

The Creoles

- American-born descendants of the early Spanish colonizers.
- Top administrative posts were reserved for the Spanish-born; representation limited to city councils handling minor local affairs.
- They financed the corregidores' purchase payments and earned interest on them, and supplied the goods for the repartimiento.
- Because those goods had to be paid in money, Indigenous people sold labor to Creole mines, textile mills and farms.

Why Spain reformed

- The British capture of Havana in 1762 showed how indefensible the empire was, and Charles III launched a broad program of colonial reform.
- José de Gálvez, *visitador general* of New Spain from 1765 to 1771, reported to the Crown in 1768: “the remedy will be to introduce the intendant system, whereby men of capacity will supplant these greedy incapable tyrants who oppress the people and absorb the revenues which they should pay to the Crown”.
- Gálvez became Secretary of the Indies in 1776 and spent years drafting the legislation. The intendants were a French institution, in place in mainland Spain since 1749.
- Lynch called the result a “second conquest of America”.

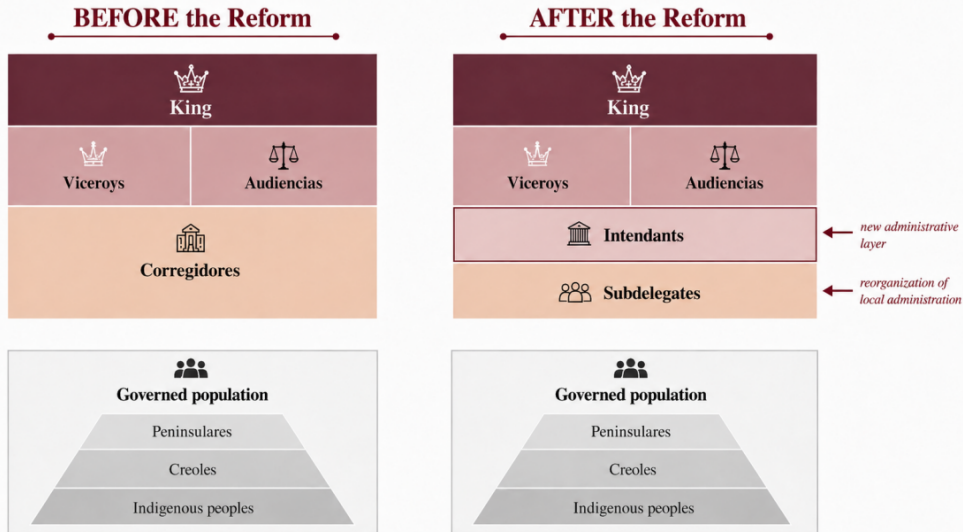
The intendency system

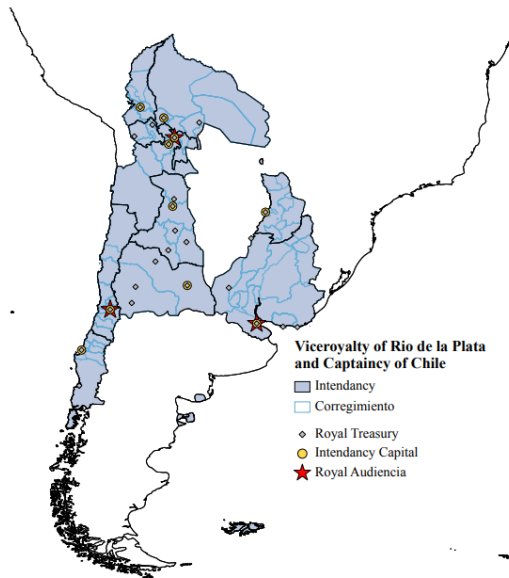
- First ordinance: Rio de la Plata, 1782, with 276 articles and eight new intendancies.
- **Intendants**: appointed by the Crown, preferably Spanish-born, carefully selected, indefinite terms, 6,000 pesos a year, authority over justice, public finance and war.
- Corregidores dismissed, replaced by **subdelegates** paid 3 to 5% of the poll tax they collected and overseen by the intendant. The repartimiento was banned.
- Lockhart and Schwartz: “The intendant was very much like a little viceroy in his own area” .

Where the authority sat

- Authority moved away from the old centers of power, but stayed in the Crown's hands.
- Lynch: “the intendant system involved no decentralization: the intendants were precisely agents of royal authority, appointed to subordinate the whole territory to central control”.
- The Creoles were not consulted on the design, and did not gain access to the new posts.

Figure C2: Organizational Structure of the Colonial Administration

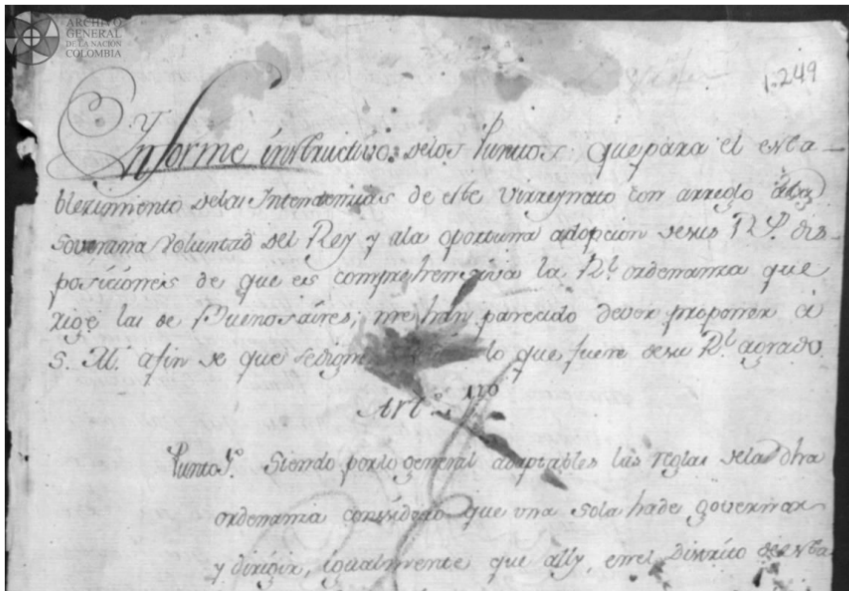




Reading the two charts

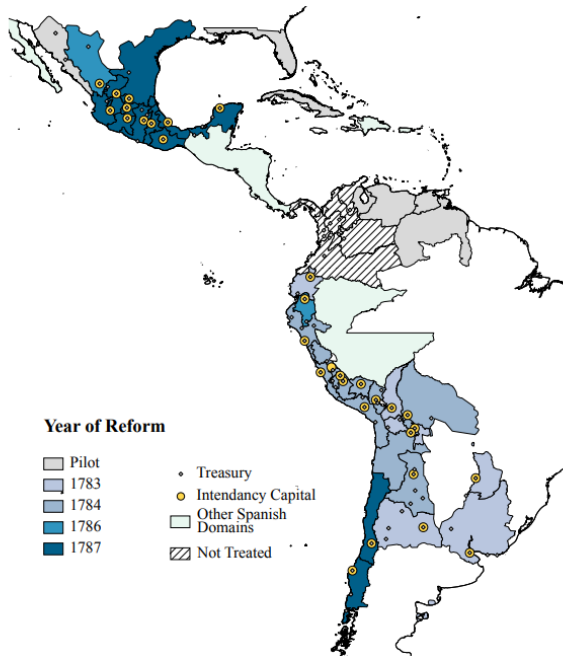
- Before: King, then viceroys and *Audiencias*, then corregidores over the governed population. After: a new intermediate layer of intendants, with subdelegates below them in the same places.
- The social hierarchy (*peninsulares*, Creoles, Indigenous peoples) is untouched.
- Second figure, Rio de la Plata and Chile: intendancies in dark outline, the old *corregimientos* in light blue. One intendancy absorbs many.
- Yellow circles are the new intendancy capitals, red stars the *Audiencias* that already existed, diamonds the royal treasuries whose accounts the paper uses.

Figure C3: First page of Ordinance of Intendants for New Granada



The reform that stopped halfway

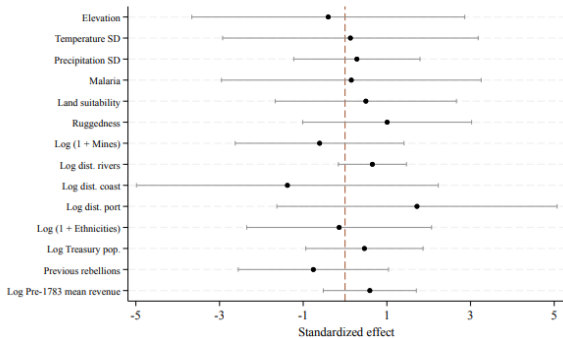
- Rio de la Plata 1782, Quito 1783, Peru 1784, Cuenca and Durango 1786, Chile and the rest of New Spain 1787.
- Gálvez died in 1787 and Charles III in 1788, and the roll-out stalled.
- The ordinance for New Granada had already been drafted, and a copy allegedly lay on Gálvez's desk when he died.
- Present-day Colombia never adopted the system, and serves as the **never-treated** comparison.



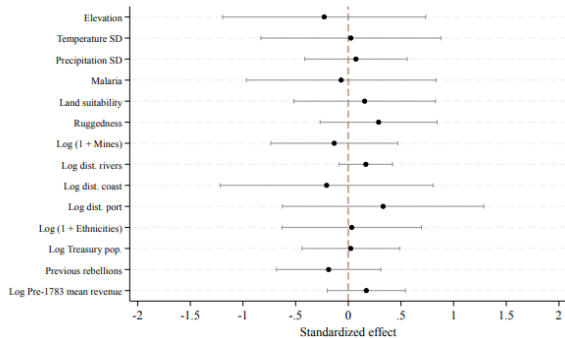
Reading the map

- Shading is the year the **first intendant actually arrived**, not the year the ordinance was issued.
- Yellow circles are intendency capitals, diamonds are royal treasuries, the hatched area is never-treated New Granada.
- The gap between ordinance and arrival ran from zero to two years.
- Causes of delay: individual appointment disputes, waiting for printed copies of the ordinance, long voyages. One intendant was captured by the British on his way to New Spain.

Figure 2: Predetermined Covariates and the Roll-out of the Intendancy System



(a) Year of adoption



(b) Late adopter

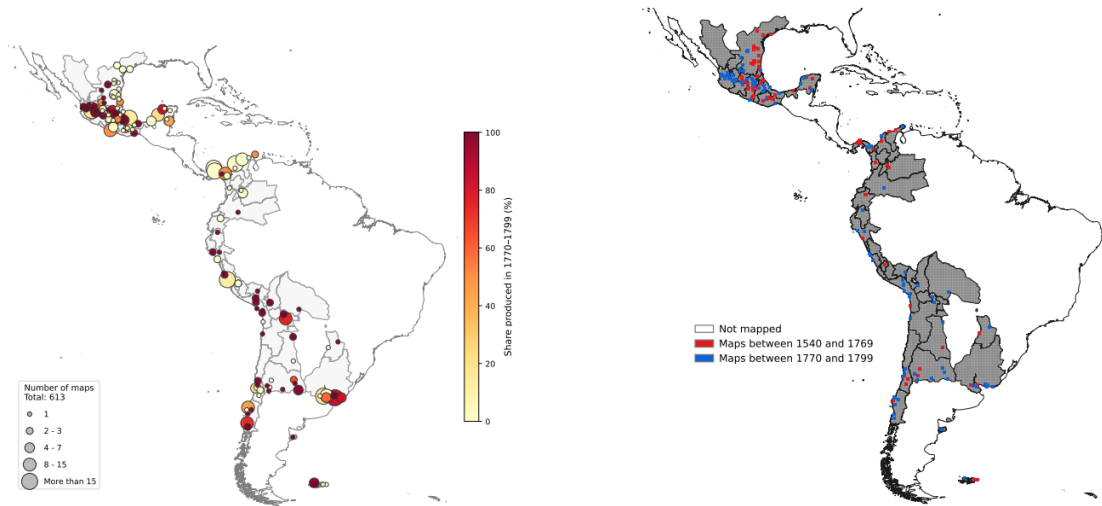
Was the timing targeted?

- Each region's pre-reform characteristics, set against when the reform arrived.
- Elevation, ruggedness, malaria, land suitability, mines, distance to rivers, coast and port.
- Population, rebellions between 1700 and 1783, average revenue before 1783.
- Nothing lines up with the timing, either with the year of adoption or with early against late adoption.

The data

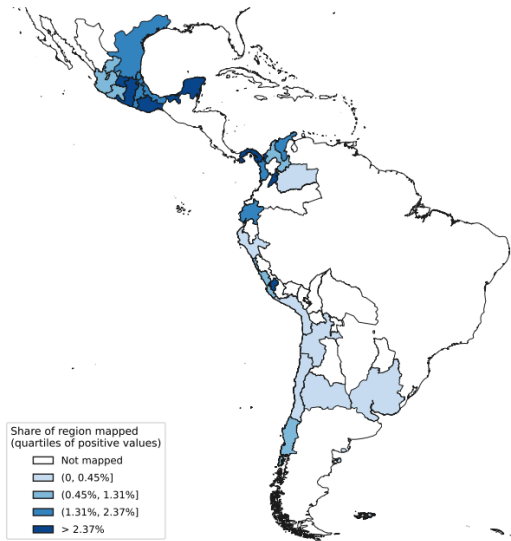
- **79 royal treasuries**, year by year, 1770 to 1799, from the accounts sent to Madrid.
- Every map of Spanish America catalogued in the **Archive of the Indies**, digitized and geocoded: 408 documents in the baseline.
- Biographies of all 86 intendants: birthplace, education, prior colonial service, tenure.
- Roughly 255,000 baptismal records; 301 Indigenous rebellions; 1,280 letters from 1807 to 1811; 2,435 notable individuals.

Figure C4: Spatial Distribution of Cartographic Information

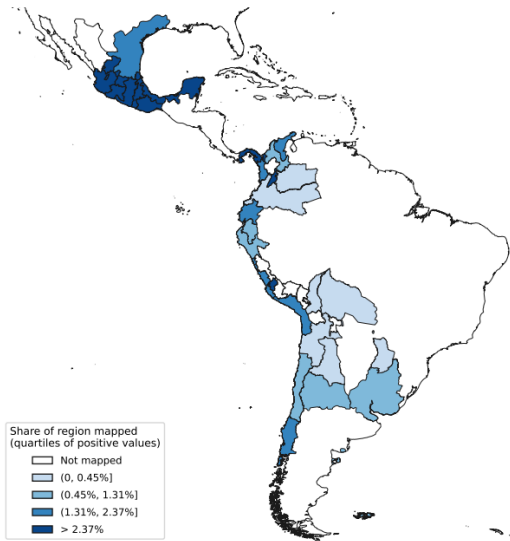


(a) Location of catalogued maps

(b) Cells with cartographic information



(c) Coverage by region, 1541–1769



(d) Coverage by region, 1541–1799

Figure C5: Locations with Baptismal Records

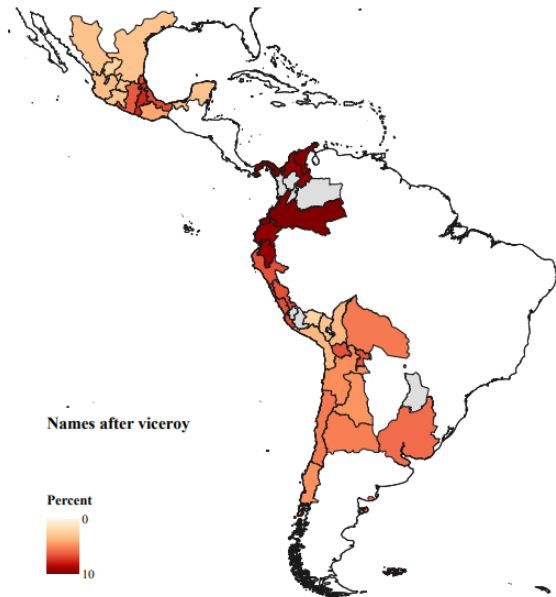


Figure C6: Location of Indigenous Rebellions

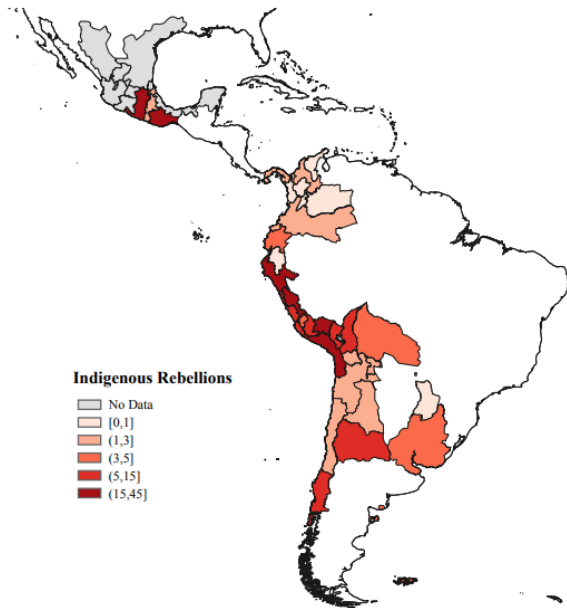


Figure C7: Locations Referenced in Correspondence

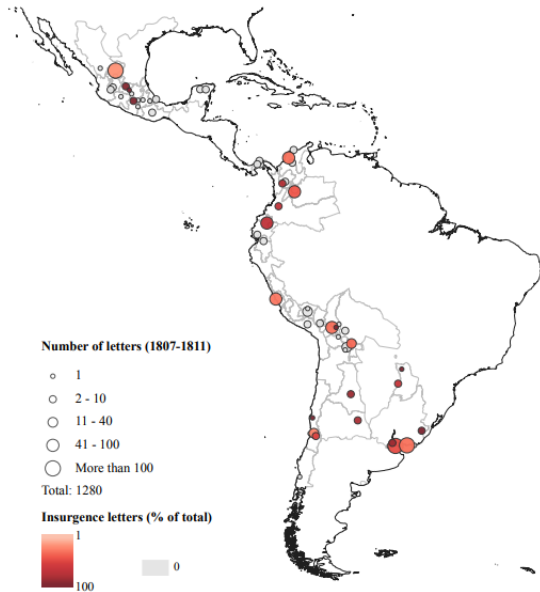
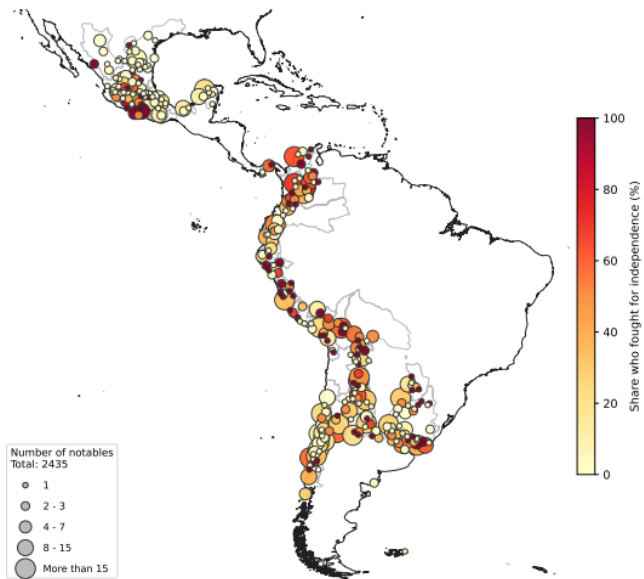


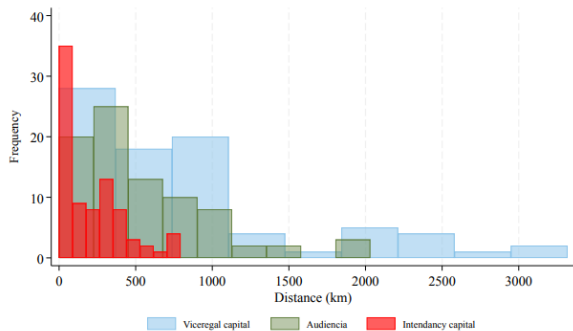
Figure C8: Locations of Birthplaces of Notable People



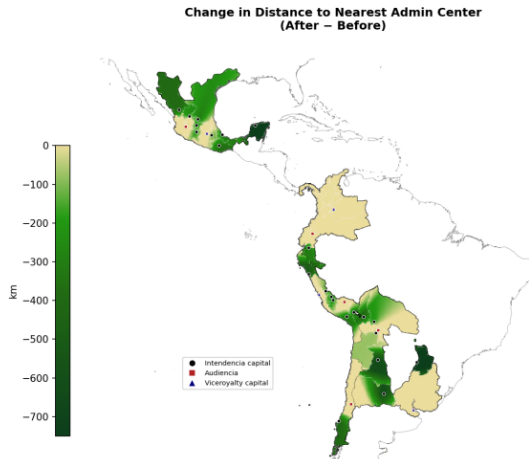
Reading the data maps

- Cartography: red cells were mapped before 1770, blue cells first mapped between 1770 and 1799; then regional coverage in quartiles, before and after. Almost the whole continent stays white.
- Baptisms: where the records come from, shaded by the share of names matching a viceroy. Urban and Creole-biased, which is the group whose loyalty is in question.
- Rebellions: 1770 to 1799, pooled from regional sources. Gray is missing data, kept distinct from areas with genuinely no rebellions.
- Independence: 1,280 letters shaded by insurrectionist share, and the birthplaces of 2,435 notables shaded by the share who fought for independence.

Figure 3: The Intendancy System and Distance to Administrative Centers

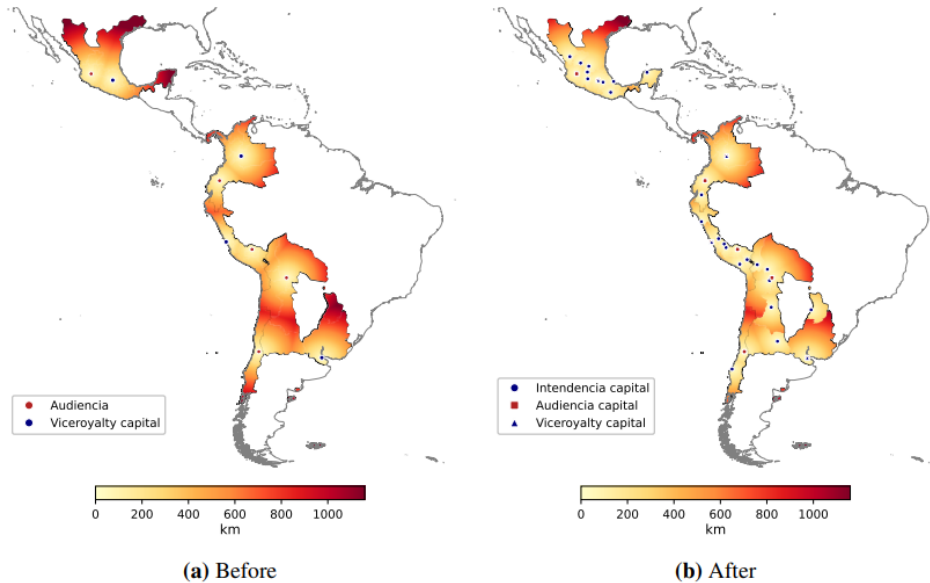


(a) Distribution



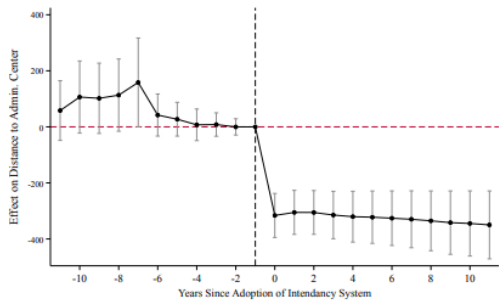
(b) Impact of intendancy system

Figure C14: Distance to the nearest administrative center: Before vs After Reform

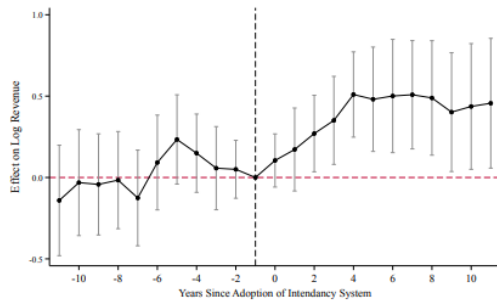


Result 1: the state gets closer

- Before the reform, the nearest top administrative center was an *Audiencia* or a viceregal capital: on average 534 km and 848 km from a treasury. After it, the intendancy capital was **200 km** away.
- Adopting the system cut that distance by about 350 km, around 70% of the pre-reform average.
- Histogram: distance to a viceregal capital can exceed 3,000 km; to an intendancy capital it mostly stays below 500 km.
- Maps: the gain is spread across the continent, largest in the Yucatan peninsula and southern Chile, and absent in Colombia. The share of territory within 300 km of an administrative center doubles, to 54%.



(a) Distance to Admin. Center



(b) Log Revenue

Result 2: revenue

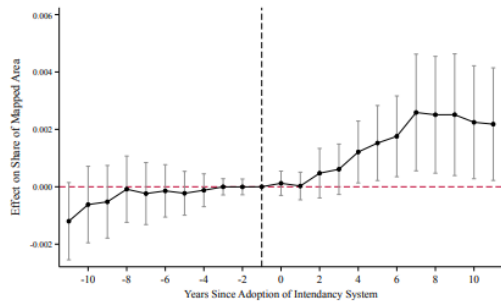
- Crown revenue in the treasuries under intendants rose by about **a third**, building over roughly five years and persisting for more than a decade.
- Panel (a): distance to the nearest administrative center, flat before, a step down on arrival. Panel (b): revenue, flat before, rising from about two years on.
- The years to the left of zero carry the argument: nothing was already moving.
- Same answer adjusting for prices, dropping remittances abroad, allowing for changes in bookkeeping, or controlling for the liberalization of maritime trade.

Where the extra revenue came from

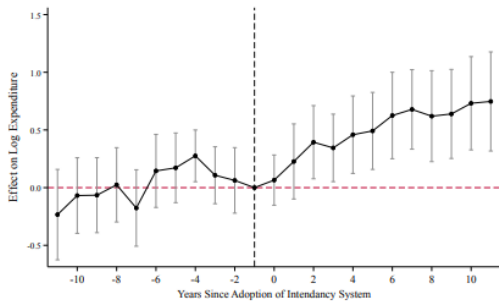
- The **Indigenous poll tax**, which the corregidores had been embezzling, and the *donativos*, mostly paid by the Creole elites.
- Both are direct taxes, politically and administratively costlier to collect, so the shift toward them is itself a sign of capacity. Indirect taxes on trade and mining shrink as a share.
- Fisher: “revenue rose in response to improved supervision and the eradication of fraud and corruption”.
- Cases: under intendant Mata in Cuzco, taxpayers and revenue rose 51% between 1784 and 1786; an intendant in Puno collected over 150,000 pesos in arrears in three years; intendant Flon of Puebla raised more than 2 million pesos in *donativos* between 1805 and 1808.

Which intendants did better

- Born outside the Americas, almost always in Spain.
- No previous experience in the colonial government, so less exposed to capture by local interests.
- Aged below fifty, plausibly with stronger career concerns: six intendants went on to become viceroys.
- Longer in post. No difference by university education, nobility or military experience.



(c) Mapped Area

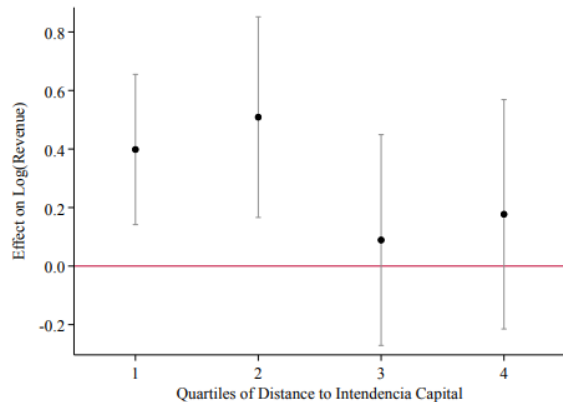


(d) Log Spending

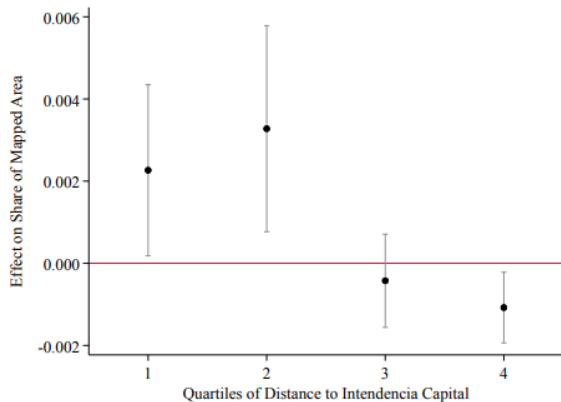
Result 3: seeing the territory

- Article 53 of the ordinance instructed intendants to report on local geography and economy.
- Mapped area rises by 0.2 percentage points, about **13%** of the sample average of 1.6%, and the count of distinct mapped locations rises by the same 13%.
- Urban and military maps drive the growth; military is the largest category, at 42%.
- Panel (c): mapped area flat before, rising gradually after, which fits a slow administrative build-up. Panel (d): spending rises about as much as revenue.

Figure 5: The Intendancy System: Interaction between territorial presence and other outcomes



(a) Fiscal capacity



(b) Informational capacity

Where the gains are

- Both panels split treasuries into quartiles of distance to the new intendency capital.
- Revenue and mapping both rise in the two nearest quartiles, and not in the farthest.
- Territorial presence is what delivers the fiscal and informational gains.
- Intendancies were vast and badly connected, and supervision did not travel.

Figure C25: The Intendancy System and Remittances to Spain

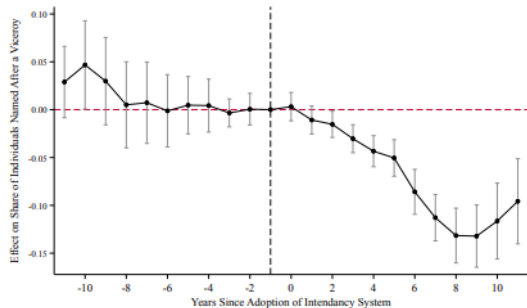


What the money bought

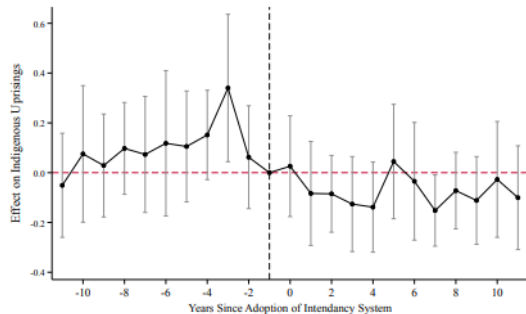
- Spending rose about as much as revenue, with no change in the chance of a deficit.
- The extra went to the military, to administration, and to remittances to Spain. Local public goods (roads, hospitals, schools) are about 3% of spending and do not move; postal offices do not move either.
- The figure: yearly colonial transfers reaching Madrid, flat and choppy, then rising sharply from the mid-1780s. Dashed lines mark the first and last waves of the reform.
- Colonial subjects were taxed more effectively and saw little of it spent where it was raised.

The authors' argument

- State capacity rose under institutions that gave the governed no voice.
- Creoles paid more, lost the repartimiento profits, and got no services in return.
- Lynch: “while the colonies were thus made to yield a greater quota of taxation, they were not consulted either about revenue or expenditure” .
- Rodríguez: “The Bourbon reformers believed in an absolutist state, not one based on consensus” .



(e) Newborns named after Viceroy



(f) Indigenous Rebellions

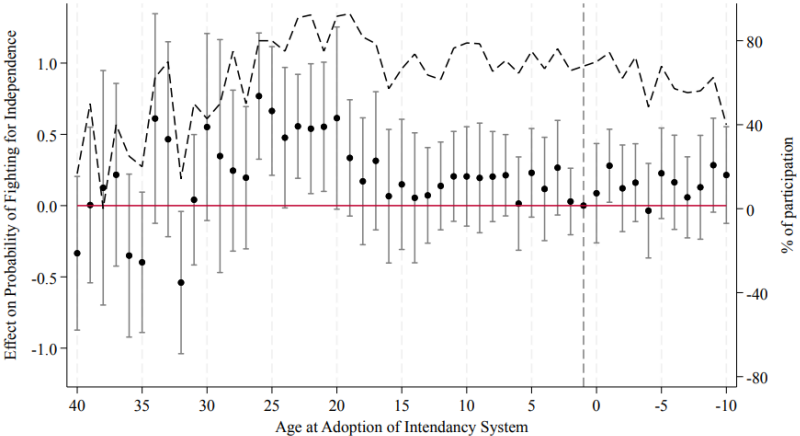
Result 4: Creole sentiment and Indigenous revolt

- The measure of Creole sentiment: the share of male newborns whose name matches the incumbent viceroy's first name. Names carried devotion, family strategy and patronage.
- Panel (e): flat before the reform, then a fall of **5 percentage points** that keeps deepening. The same fall appears using the King's name.
- Panel (f): Indigenous uprisings fall by 16 percentage points, close to the whole average incidence. The spike just before the reform is the Túpac Amaru insurrection.
- Removing the corregidor cost the Creoles their intermediary and their repartimiento profits, and removed the main thing Indigenous communities had been rebelling against.

Relief or repression?

- If repression drove the fall, it should be larger where military spending was high, or under intendants with military careers. It is not.
- The fall is larger where the Indigenous poll tax had been highest before the reform.
- Poll tax revenue rose while rebellions fell: the formal tax and the effective burden are different things.
- The repartimiento and the abuses in collection were the burden, and both went. Von Humboldt in 1811: “the establishment of intendancies, during the ministry of Gálvez was a memorable epoque for Indian prosperity”.

Figure 6: Exposure to the Intendancy System and Participation in the Independence Movement



Result 5: independence

- The intendancies whose revenue rose most produced more insurrectionist correspondence in **1807-1811**: a 10% higher revenue gain goes with 1.4 percentage points more insurrectionist letters, about 12% of the average.
- The figure: age when the intendancy system arrived in the person's region of birth, against the chance of fighting for independence.
- Effects are near zero for those who were small children, or not yet born, and rise for those in the impressionable years of 18 to 25.
- The dashed line is raw participation by cohort, flat enough that the pattern is not mechanical. 15% of serving intendants were killed in the events around 1810.

Robustness, and the counterfactual

- Estimators built for reforms that arrive in waves give the same answer, and dropping any single treasury, region or viceroyalty changes nothing.
- Randomizing the timing and location of the reform 500 times puts the real estimates far out in the tail. Controlling for the announcement date confirms it is the intendant's arrival that matters.
- Napoleon invaded Spain in 1807; Charles IV abdicated and Ferdinand VII was overthrown in 1808; the first declarations of independence follow in 1809.
- Their reading: Napoleon was “the matchstick that set the empire on fire”, and Creole animosity was the fuel.

Putting the two papers together

- Both study elite recruitment inside a regime with no electoral channel for discontent.
- Bai and Jia: closing the route into the elite mobilized the people who were queuing for it.
- Chiovelli et al.: professionalizing the state stripped privileges from the elite that already had them.
- Opposite reforms. In both, the regime lost the group best placed to organize against it.